Indigenous People and Media Representation in Journalism

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Abstract

This research paper examines how media sources with varying political biases cover indigenous events in Ecuador and their implications for media representation of marginalized communities worldwide. Specifically, the study analyzes the coverage of recent protests led by indigenous organizations in Ecuador. It highlights the importance of including indigenous perspectives in media coverage to promote a more accurate and nuanced understanding of indigenous issues. The research finds that media representation of indigenous people varies depending on the political bias of the news source and suggests that media sources should strive for objective and balanced reporting to avoid perpetuating harmful stereotypes and biases. This study underscores the need for media sources to include marginalized perspectives in their coverage and for readers to seek out multiple sources to form informed opinions.

Indigenous People and Media Representation in Journalism

Indigenous people are an essential topic, and there is a severe lack of representation in the media. This analysis will outline the media representation of indigenous people regarding human rights violations. The key points of media representation of international events where human rights violations occur are a set of key features of the reporting in the media. The goal of this research is to help readers of journalism understand the common factors of these types of journalism are not isolated events. Throughout the events, the research's burden of proof will need multiple varieties of journalism to show how various sources will report the same series of events to their audiences.

This research will provide the timeline of events of political and environmental issues in Ecuador while particularly analyzing one set of protests to show the difference in political coverage based on audience, rhetoric, and political bias.

Introduction of Events

The complete timeline of events begins in January of 2022 when the OCP, or Ecuador's Heavy Crude Oil Pipeline, ruptured, contaminating more than 20,000 square meters of the Cayambe Coca National Park (Mongabay, 2022). The events started in 2020 when pipelines started to burst, and since the first burst in April of 2020, the OCP Ecuador contractors have built more pipelines that have failed and collapsed. At the same time, OCP Ecuador has claimed that habitual rain has caused moisture which causes rocks to fall and then crash into the pipeline, eventually causing bursts and spills. The President of OCP Ecuador claimed that "The [study of the physical characteristics of rocks] here is very complicated, but citizens must understand — the way that all the authorities have understood — that we don't have much choice here; we had

several route options, but all of them were ruled out at the time because we came across new things or much bigger problems." (Mongabay, 2022).

Another report by Mongabay in 2022 shows more information regarding the indigenous people's lives and the Ecuadorian government. Efren Nango, an education officer for the Confederation of Indigenous Nationalities of the Ecuadorian Amazon (CONFENIAE) shares his story of the oil pipeline bursts and other events. In the article, Nango says, "The Ecuadoran state always came with an extractivist vision. If you wanted to stimulate the economy and generate employment, they would say you always had to extract oil or have mines because that's where the money is." (Mongabay, 2022). This follows a report of the Chevron corporation being ordered to pay out $9.5 billion in damages to 30,000 plaintiffs. Chevron refused and launched a lawsuit against Steven Donziger, who launched the initial litigation (Mongabay, 2022). Jamie Guevara, the Pastaza prefect leader, said the conservation launched by their local government would create 12 million acres of forest for conservation. The article ends with the explanation that Ecuadoran President Guillermo Lasso passed decrees to boost investments in oil and mining to boost the economy.

In late 2022, Mongabay reported of Gold Mining that extended into the remote protected areas. Mongabay's article says "Data and imagery from Global Forest Watch show clearings proliferating along rivers that form the northern and southern borders of Cofán Bermejo Ecological Reserve. Clearing activity also appears to be piercing the western portion of the reserve" (Mongabay, 2022). Much of the ecological effects from the illegal mining are impacting fishing communities where the water is cloudy and water levels are very low. The government has been aware of the illegal mining but has stated that "it has been difficult for MAATE

officials to enter the reserve and carry out enforcement activities for the past two years" (Mongabay, 2022).

This timeline of events are the ecological effects of the mining and oil in Ecuador but does not acknowledge the human impact of the mining and oil. Reports from other sources outside of Mongabay (which is a non-profit based in the United States that covers conservation and environmental science news), show the protests and deaths that occur. Reuters reported in September of 2022 that the Ecuadorian government had struck a temporary deal to pause the environmental exploitation of the forests (Reuters, 2022). According to CNN, this was following a set of protests that left four people dead. CNN also reported that 100 people were arrested during the set of protests (CNN, 2022). On March 3rd, 2023, Human Rights Watch reported that a key opposition leader was reported to have been killed during a raid (HRW, 2023). While there is little information from the Ecuadorian government, there is a tweet from the Ecuadorian president which tweeted solidarity with the gentleman and his family. The rough translation via Twitter says "The Government of Ecuador expresses its solidarity with the family of Eduardo Mendúa and with CONAIE. This crime will not go unpunished" (Lasso, 2023).

In summary, the timeline of events regarding the ecological effects of mining and oil in Ecuador reveals a complex and ongoing issue that has caused significant damage to the environment and impacted the lives of indigenous people. From pipeline ruptures and spills to illegal mining and protests, the events illustrate the challenging social, political, and economic factors that influence the management of natural resources in the region. While there have been some efforts to address these issues, much more needs to be done to ensure the protection of indigenous rights and the preservation of the environment for future generations. The

background context is necessary for understanding the inclusion or exclusion of information when analyzing media coverage from around the world.

Methods

This analysis examines journalism using international, domestic, and independent sources to show how rhetoric changes beyond their normal audience when the journalism is not about their normal audience. There will also be a key emphasis on the background given to the audience when it is a story that is not well known to their main and general audience. The entire article of journalism will highlight how the context is portrayed to the audience. Along with the journalism showcased, the research will also introduce Ecuadorian government sources to see how their rhetoric changes.

Research Design

The analysis investigates certain artifacts of the Ecuadorian oil and indigenous people's clash and protests. I am hoping to find key differences between the different sources and how there is backtracking and information of key events that lead to certain events, such as protests or killings. There is also the question of who the audience is, does it change by media source or is it a general audience for each story? I also want to investigate bias, rhetoric, and tone for these stories, for example, does one news source attempt to invoke certain emotions because their audience will differ from a different media source?

The media sources will be gathered via a search engine using keywords such as "Ecuadorian Protests" or "Ecuadorian Indigenous People". Rather than limiting the search via academic databases, I believe an ordinary search engine, such as Google, will be useful to gather

stories from sources that an average reader may find. This study excludes traffic from sources such as social media.

Sources ranged from domestic sources, such as CNN and Fox, for United States journalism and sources such as Reuters and the Associated Press for international journalism sources. This gives the range of bias from one side to another, speaking of political affiliation as a key guideline of affiliation. The selection for journalism follows areas that are "Ecuadorian" or "Amazonian" with an emphasis on Ecuador.

Data Analysis and Guideline

The emphasis on analysis on these pieces of journalism will be from an outside source to gather political affiliation. The website "All Sides" will be used to gain how much a political affiliation or bias a certain media source has. According to All Sides, their methodology includes editorial review, blind bias survey, independent review, third party data, and community feedback. The website rates their confidence level between low, media, or high. While the information that comes in is community driven and not scientifically proven, it will give the reader a basic guideline to follow how much of a bias or affiliation a media source has. According to All Sides, the editorial review includes a panel for understanding bias in political affiliation. "The panel looks for common types of media bias such as slant, spin, sensationalism, and story choice. … Editorial Reviews are designed to be multipartisan. Because bias is in the eye of the beholder, each reviewer has a subjective opinion on the source's bias. Often there is broad agreement; other times, reviewers share evidence and deliberate" (All Sides, 2023). The ratings from All Sides follows only the online media and does not include social media, TV broadcasts, or radio broadcasts.

Much of the audience will be inferred based on the rhetoric used as the audience will change day-to-day and source-to-source. The political affiliation of each media source will be a source to infer what the audience could be. Understanding the audience is important as the rhetoric used will cater to that audience while excluding other readers. The specific word choice, such as a comparison with CNN and Fox will differ, giving more political bias than the other. While this is not exclusive to the United States's brand of journalism, it will be a source of audience. This also gives us, the researcher(s), information on why a certain tone or choice of rhetoric is used.

After choosing which media sources to use, the text will be analyzed by the rhetoric, information provided or excluded, and location and timing of the publication. These factors will determine how the audience may interpret the information given and to whom the audience will be. Instead of looking at the sources as independent, they will be analyzed together to compare information provided to the reader. This will determine how much of a conversation and voice are given to indigenous people and if the media source is helping or hindering the voices of indigenous people, especially those in remote regions such as Ecuador. The limitation of the research is the inference of audience which may not always be true, but the information from All Sides gives credibility to the overall political affiliation based previous iterations of media.

Rhetorical Analysis

Outside Literature

An article outlining media representation of indigenous people in the United States gives context to how important media conversation is to journalism as a genre. In an article by Tristan Ahtone of the Nieman Reports, which is affiliated with Harvard University, it outlines the story

of Cree woman Connie Oakes. It covers how a woman lied to the police during investigations which lead to Connie Oakes being assumed guilty in a murder which she claimed innocence (Ahtone, 2017). The article titled "Telling Indigenous Stories" shares how the media industry has historically marginalized and excluded indigenous communities from coverage.

Ahtone says that "[their] insufficient to nonexistent coverage of their communities not only represents a missed opportunity, but a significant failure for an industry hoping to find voice and relevance in the 21st century" (Ahtone, 2017). The article hits key points of how indigenous people's communities are diverse and have unique stories and issues that deserve attention. The rise of digital media presents new mediums for these conversations and stories, but media outlets must cover these stories on their own terms.

Ahtone acknowledges that there are significant barriers to break, especially those of lack of funding, limited access to technology and internet, and ongoing discrimination and bias outside of their communities. Ahtone believes that to truly address these issues, the media industry must commit to incorporating indigenous perspectives into their coverage, from news stories to entertainment and cultural content (Ahtone, 2017).

Outlining Political Bias

Using All Sides, we can give a basic outline of political affiliation over some media sources. For Reuters, which will be the guideline and politically centralized source, as the guideline for all other media. According to All Sides, Reuters is rated as center political bias with a medium confidence in the bias rating. Out of 35,564 people (as of April 26, 2023), there is 59.1% confidence based on the community of Reuters being a center politically biased source of media (All Sides, 2023).

For Fox News, there are two sources based on All Sides. One being the online news section and the other source being the opinion pieces posted to Fox News online. For this research, I will be analyzing the online news section of Fox News based on All Sides. Fox News is rated as Right that "display media bias in ways that strongly align with conservative, traditional, or right-wing thought and/or policy agendas" (All Sides, 2023). The confidence level of their bias level is rated as high confidence and bias reviews affirm that the rating or source is transparent of this bias. 106,341 in the community, the split is negligible 50/50 to the thousandths place. All Sides acknowledges that the community disagrees with right, and that Fox News instead has a Lean Right bias.

The last domestic source is CNN, which also has two sections of news, one being opinion and the other being online news. Again, this research covers the online news section of CNN. All Sides has given CNN a Lean Left bias rating with medium confidence in the bias rating. This means that as a media bias that is Lean Left "display[s] media bias in ways that moderately align with liberal, progressive, or left-wing thought and/or policy agendas" (All Sides, 2023). The 114,277 people that provided feedback on the political bias of lean left, those who did not agree suggested that CNN leaned left. Note that from All Sides, the bias has shifted recently from Left to Lean Left.

News sources from AP, or Associated Press, will also be used. For this research, while US based, AP will be classified as an international or independent news source. All Sides defines them from moving Center to Lean Left with medium confidence in that rating (All Sides, 2023).

As established, the political bias will give insight to the general audience that each news source intends their audience to be. Without understanding the political bias of each news source, there is no information on the audience left. This would leave the reader to infer what rhetoric is

used, with the outline of political bias we can give context outside of the story to the rhetoric that may be used in conveying information to the reader.

Rhetorical Analysis on Ecuadorian Protests

The first set of articles regards a series of protests. The protests follow the Ecuadorian President Guillermo Lasso's decision to cut gasoline prices, which is unrelated from the oil contamination from oil pipelines failing. Each article will cover the same stories, but with different rhetoric, background, and conclusions from the other media sources.

CNN. The article is short and to the point. The article is titled "Four dead in Ecuador's anti-government protests". It gives the context of how many days there have been protests in Ecuador, while attempting to be as politically central as possible. From the article:

> At least four people have died amid ongoing protests against the government of Ecuadorian President Guillermo Lasso, according to Ecuadorian authorities. Scores of police officers have been injured and more than 100 people have been arrested, authorities also said.
>
> Thursday marks the eleventh day of protest in the country. The Confederation of Indigenous Nationalities of Ecuador (Conaie), which has been leading the protests since June 13, is demanding that the government reduce fuel prices, address the problem of unemployment, regulate farm product prices, and fight crime, among other pleas. (CNN, 2022).

The rhetoric used is clear and concise. The background given is limited to only this event with some historical context of why the protests are continuing to happen. The audience rating

from All Sides gives CNN Lean Left, but there is little to no evidence of blatant coverage from one side of the political spectrum to another.

FOX News. The similar event, while posted online a few days later, follows the protests in Ecuador. The title of the article is "US ally Ecuador faces worsening crisis: government could collapse". The second paragraph of the article states:

> The protests have been mostly led by Indigenous groups who blame the government for not complying with their demand to reduce fuel prices, control prices on agricultural products and set a larger budget for education. But some conservative analysts say this is just an excuse to stage a coup against the government because leftist groups want to take power at any price. (FOX News, 2022).

The first thing to note in this quote is the charged rhetoric used. Negative words such as "blame" are used. There is also outside research from conservative analysts with no citation or further research available for the reader to corroborate their own political views on the event.

There is plenty of historical and background research given to the reader of the government of Ecuador with US-based rhetoric. It also gives context on the previous incumbent of the Ecuadorian President office saying:

> Observers say that former leftist president Rafael Correa, who left office in 2017, is a fierce opponent of the present government and still maintains enormous influence and seeks to return to power at any price, and the radicalization of the indigenous group protesting, known as CONAIE (Confederation of Indigenous Nationalities of Ecuador) is one of his strategies to take power. (FOX News, 2022).

The context helps the reader to understand but gives less room for inference by the reader to formulate their own opinion. With All Sides giving FOX News a Right rating of political bias, the issue moves away from protests and towards drug-trafficking and how it affects the United States. A Research fellow from the IEEP claimed that "There was a very strong complicity between the previous governments that were quite close to these leftist movements financed by drug trafficking" (FOX News, 2022).

FOX News moves the story away from indigenous people and relates this story to their audience. It dilutes the indigenous voice and creates a dangerous rhetoric of drug-trafficking that could possibly affect the audience member.

AP News. As established AP News according to All Sides has moved to the Lean Left position, with a historical political bias of central. Seeing how AP News is a collaboration of journalism across the world, we will trust the confidence that AP News is central with different and leaning views politically.

The information given sufficiently encompasses the protests, why there are protests, and how these effect indigenous people in Ecuador. The title of the article is "Group leading protests OKs dialogue with Ecuador government". The article opens:

> The Indigenous organization leading protests in Ecuador on Monday agreed to discuss with the government possible solutions that could lead to the end of a strike that has paralyzed parts of the country for two weeks.
>
> The Confederation of Indigenous Nationalities of Ecuador said in a statement that it was expecting to meet with government officials on the same day of the announcement. Its

decision followed President Guillermo Lasso's announcement of a gasoline price cut, which has been one of the group's demands. (Associated Press, 2022).

The article gives voices to the indigenous people explaining their demands from their 10-point agenda, quoting "including the reduction of the price of extra gasoline from 2.55 to 2.10 dollars a gallon and diesel from 1.90 to 1.50" (Associated Press, 2022). It also expands that the indigenous people are demanding "a cut in gasoline prices, price controls on agricultural products and a larger budget be set for education" (2022). They also acknowledge that the Ecuadorian President has accused the leader of attempting to stage a coup against the government.

The article also acknowledges that "protesters blocking roads have brought the city to a near halt and people are experiencing food and fuel shortages. Groups of protesters have roamed the city attacking vehicles and civilians and forcing the closure of businesses, some of which were looted" (2022). This article gives full historical background and context to the reader without leaving information out, and without leading the reader to assume or suggest certain things.

Rhetorical Analysis Conclusion

While all three sources cover the ongoing protests in Ecuador, there are apparent differences in how they report on the events. CNN offers a relatively balanced perspective, providing context and information without appearing to take a specific political stance. On the other hand, FOX News presents a more partisan view, with language that appears to favor the government and conservative analysts and emphasizes the role of drug trafficking in the protests, which could be seen as a tactic to shift focus away from the demands of the indigenous people.

Meanwhile, AP News offers a more in-depth and nuanced view of the situation, focusing on the demands of the indigenous groups and their attempts to negotiate with the government.

The different biases of the news sources highlight the importance of media literacy and critical thinking skills when consuming news. Readers must be aware of the potential political leanings and motivations of news outlets and seek out multiple sources to gain a more complete and accurate understanding of complex events.

Furthermore, it is crucial to consider the voices and perspectives centered or marginalized in news coverage. In the case of the protests in Ecuador, the indigenous people are leading the protests and demanding change. Still, some sources, such as FOX News, downplay or ignore their voices, while others, such as AP News, give them more space to express their perspectives and demands. The coverage of the protests in Ecuador by these three news sources highlights the importance of critically analyzing news and seeking out diverse perspectives to better understand complex events.

Implications of the Research

The research shows how media representation of indigenous people will differentiate based on the audience who is consuming the media. While some political sources will cater to a different subset of readers, the rhetoric used during their coverage will key readers into what political bias the organization follows. Some will show less political bias, such as being clear and concise and giving the readers only pivotal information regarding the story being covered.

As Ahtone mentioned in his article, there are dangers for muting or silencing indigenous peoples' voices. Media coverage requires that this subset of people on Earth require attention and without it, stories like this one, and the story that Ahtone covered, will reach nobody outside of

the indigenous people's communities. Like Ahtone mentioned, media coverage must include indigenous people, not just in the United States, but around the world as well.

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